

One limitation of using Grad Café data for statistical analysis is that all the information is anonymously submitted and self-reported. The people who choose to post their results may not represent everyone who applies to graduate school. For example, someone who had a positive, negative, or unusual application experience might be more likely to share their results. This can create selection bias because the dataset is based on people who voluntarily submitted their information instead of a random sample of graduate school applicants. There can also be issues with missing or incorrect information since users may leave fields blank, enter something incorrectly, or report information in different formats. Because of this, calculations like average GPA or GRE scores only reflect the usable information that was submitted.

This is important to keep in mind when looking at the results from my own analysis. For example, my dataset calculated an average GRE Quantitative score of 190.06. While that is what my database mathematically calculated from the available data, it does not mean that 190.06 represents the average GRE score of graduate school applicants in the real world. In fact, a result like this shows why the quality of the original data matters so much. The number could be affected by incorrect entries, missing information, how the data was processed, or which applicants chose to report their scores. Certain schools or programs may also be more represented on Grad Café than others. Overall, the analysis can tell me what is contained in my dataset, but I must be careful about using those results to make conclusions about graduate school applicants.